Carpet-weavers, Morocco

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‘Carpet-Weavers, Morocco’

Here is a detailed guide to Carol Rumens’ poem ‘Carpet-Weavers, Morocco’, from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods**: an exploration of Rumens’ poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of the themes and ideas within Rumens’ poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Carol Rumens’ intention and message

‘Carpet-Weavers, Morocco’ overview

Carol Rumens’ poem depicts a speaker watching young people weaving carpets in Morocco. Rumens describes children focused on intricate work, and how the carpet they weave has a spiritual nature. The poem links an everyday practice for the children to their culture, religion and the world around them.

‘Carpet-Weavers, Morocco’ breakdown

Line 1

Translation

- The poem begins with an omniscient narrator describing the concentrated activities of children weaving at a "loom", a tool for weaving threads
- The narrator suggests they are transported to "another world", as if daydreaming

Rumens' intentions

- The poem introduces the children as mesmerised by their weaving, which brings a magical or mystical quality to the poem

Lines 2-3

> **"Their braids are oiled and black, their dresses bright.**
> **Their assorted heights would make a melodious chime."**

Translation

- The narrator describes their hair and bright clothing
- The children are all different ages

Rumens' intentions

- Rumens draws attention to the vivid and sensual appearance of the children:
  - She juxtaposes the darkness of the children's hair with the bright colours of their clothes
  - This suggests there is beauty alongside mistreatment and darkness (of child labour)
- She compares their different heights to a tune made by different keys, suggesting the group works harmoniously

Lines 4-6

> **"They watch their flickering knots like television.**
> **As the garden of Islam grows, the bench will be raised.**
> **Then they will lace the dark-rose veins of the tree-tops."**

Translation

- The narrator describes the way the children focus on weaving as if it was "television"
- The poet describes their carpet as a "garden of Islam", perhaps alluding to the designs of flowers and trees that the Moroccan children weave into the carpet
- As the carpet increases in size, they begin to move onto threading roses into the "treetops" (a design on the carpet)

through the Western reference to "television" and the Moroccan reference to "Islam"
- Rumens compares the carpet to a "garden of Islam" to suggest the carpet is an important part of the Islam tradition, as well as to describe the carpet's detail

Lines 7-9

> **"The carpet will travel in the merchant's truck.**
> **It will be spread by the servants of the mosque.**
> **Deep and soft, it will give when heaped with prayer."**

Translation

- The narrator considers the future of the carpet, imaging how it will be taken by the "merchant" or carpet-seller, to a mosque
- It will be soft and comfortable when the many worshippers kneel on it to pray

Rumens' intentions

- Rumens links the carpet to religion, specifically Islam, and how the children's weaving has a deeper purpose
- The repetition of "will" suggests certainty, perhaps implying that the children are also trapped in a system that they cannot escape from
- She describes its significance with the metaphor, "heaped with prayer"

Line 10

> **"The children are hard at work in the school of days."**

Translation

- The narrator says that the children learn as they work and that, while they are not at school, they work hard

Rumens' intentions

- Rumens changes the traditional phrase "school days" to show the different lives of children who work instead of going to school
- There is an implication that their "hard at work" is a daily occurrence

Lines 11-12

Translation

- The poem ends by describing how the colours of the carpet appear to "fly" from the children's fast "fingers"
- The final line concludes that the carpets are a symbol of the future and the past

Rumens' intentions

- The poem ends with a metaphor that alludes to the children's skilful work
- The carpet under their masterful hands is like a "frame" or canvas that represents timeless cultural traditions

Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes and, specifically, the "deeper meanings of the poem". Examiners advise you to spend more time thinking about, for example, the reason a poet raises certain themes. Sometimes, a poet raises themes and concerns about their own background or society. Other poets may wish to explore unfamiliar cultural identities and environments.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet's overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Carol Rumens' intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Rumens' free-flowing rhythm and steady voice contributes to the reflective nature of the poem.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention

	tone, but alliteration adds drama to the scene, such as in "fingers" and "fly, and in end-stopped lines that disrupt the poem's fluidity	weaving, yet there are hints at more salient thoughts, such as references to "television", "merchant's trucks", and "school of days"

Structure

Carol Rumens structures the poem into regular three line stanzas that progress through an omniscient narrator's observations and thoughts.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Cultural identity	The poem is constructed as four tercets which describe a Moroccan carpet as it is presently, and as it will be in the future	Rumens' poem describes the children who weave a Moroccan carpet, and reflects on the timeless significance of the carpet as a symbol of cultural identity
		The poem looks regular and carefully crafted, just as the carpet is.
	The poet uses enjambment in the final line	This symbolises the leap across time that the lines describe

Language

Carol Rumens uses vivid imagery to describe the beauty of the carpets the children weave. She makes allusions to the sacred place the carpets hold in Islam tradition.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Cultural identity	The metaphor, "loom of another world" alludes to the spiritual qualities of the carpet, while the "garden of Islam" and "dark-rose veins" brings the carpet to life as if a living thing that will soon be "heaped with prayers"	Rumens emphasises the intricate detail of carpets weaved in Morocco, and highlights their spiritual significance across time, in "all-that-will-be" and "all-that-was"

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore** the **writer's intentions and methods**. This section has been divided into two main themes that Carol Rumens explores in her poem 'Carpet-Weavers, Morocco':

- Cultural identity

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Writing an introduction can be tricky. Examiners are clear about what they are looking for, though. They reward essays that introduce a "personal and evaluative engagement". To do this, spend time thinking about the question before writing your answer. Ask yourself how the poet raises themes, and why they want their readers to consider these ideas. Often, the poet's aims are connected to the society in which they live, or their personal background. Examiners ask that you use contextual information like this, as support for a personal interpretation.

Cultural identity

- Carol Rumens is a British poet born in 1947:
  - Her work often explores foreign cultures, histories and traditions
- In Rumens' poem, 'Carpet-Weavers, Morocco', she considers the lives of children who work as carpet-weavers day after day:
  - She contrasts them with children who watch "television" and go to school
  - The poem draws attention to the "hard work" they complete day after day
- This poem raises the profile of the culture and traditions of Morocco:
  - In the poem a narrator, clearly unfamiliar with the strange weaving of Moroccan carpets, is fascinated by their skill and focus
  - Rumens examines the significance of the carpet in Moroccan culture
  - A "merchant" will take it to a "mosque"
  - It must be soft for the worshipper's knees when it becomes "heaped with prayer"

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: what the question is asking and how to get full marks. You will also find an example of a full, annotated model answer.

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

Sources

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